

Thoughts on ai and the environment??

Posted by u/Picklesaresoyum • 0 points • 5 comments

Today is a good day to learn

Hi I just wanted to come on here and open a discussion to hear your thoughts on the issues regarding generative AI and the environment.

I have a few general prompt questions to start off but feel free to add or discuss anything else about the topic

1. Do you think AI is at a place where we can't live without it?
2. How aware are about the implications that AI has on the environment
3. Do you think the good outweighs the bad?
4. If power and water consumption are the concerns, how would you propose we regulate it, and how would you enforce it?
5. Would these regulations be implemented for all equally or would they have exemption for certain companies.

Also I'm not here to tell you stop using AI, I just wanna hear people's overall thoughts. :)

Comments

u/archpaw • 1 points • 2025-03-31 21:13 UTC

> Do you think AI is at a place where we can't live without it?

No. I like AI, but it's not like I'd die without it.

> How aware are about the implications that AI has on the environment

Mostly that they're overblown. Especially the water part.

> Do you think the good outweighs the bad?

For AI as it is now, yes. If we keep focusing on making it smarter as fast as we can and only worrying about making it friendly as an afterthought... still probably better than not doing it at all, but we really should slow down.

> If power and water consumption are the concerns, how would you propose we regulate it, and how

would you enforce it?

Taxes. Specifically, tax fossil fuels and water use. I doubt this would have any significant effect on AI, but it would matter a lot for things that are more reliant on it.

> Would these regulations be implemented for all equally or would they have exemption for certain companies.

There'd be stuff like if you're making plastic with oil instead of burning it, you don't have to pay the tax (or you get reimbursed of the tax was paid further up the production line), but not the thing cap and trade has where they're effectively paying whatever companies they decide to give a big cap to.

u/IHOP_007 • 1 points • 2025-03-31 19:17 UTC

I think to ask meaningful questions you have to define what "AI" is, cause we've been using "AI" (in some capacity) basically since computers were invented, like there was a computer in the 1950s that you could play chess against.

I'm assuming we're talking about the current large-language AI models or Generative AI art/graphic things:

- 1) No, it's a useful tool in some instances but it's mostly a convenience thing right now.
- 2) I think it has the same implication that most other computer-related things have, it ranges from being fairly green (in the grand scheme of productivity/entertainment) in areas with greener power generation and not-so-much in areas with less green power generation. Like where I live all of our power (pretty much) is hydroelectric so it's got minimal environmental impact.
- 3) I don't think that's really a question you can answer. Are baseball bats good or bad? You can create a national sport and pastime with one or you can beat someone to death with it.
- 4) Same way you regulate emissions in every other industry, you charge the power plant a carbon tax and they either generate greener power or pass on that tax to the consumer of the electricity.
- 5) You'd probably have exemptions for companies manufacturing necessary goods, most "AI" based businesses probably wouldn't fall under that.

u/Bobbob34 • 2 points • 2025-03-31 19:17 UTC

Do your own homework.

u/TheApiary • 1 points • 2025-03-31 19:11 UTC

1. No, I think at this point we could live without it. It makes my life easier, but I got along okay without it and I still could if it disappears
2. I'm pretty aware! I know that each AI query I make uses about as much as streaming a video for 2 minutes, or running my fridge for a few seconds. So multiplied over the population, that adds up, but my individual use is pretty small compared to lots of other things people do all the time (eg, avoiding one flight will make a way bigger difference than all the AI use a normal person could use in a year).
3. I think there are a lot of potential really bad harms from AI, and also some really huge possible benefits (like discovering new drugs for conditions that we don't know how to treat yet) and am not sure which will be bigger

4. I don't think those are the main concerns compared to all the other problems

5. I think regulations should generally be applied fairly and not just to specific companies

u/eggs-benedryl • 1 points • 2025-03-31 19:09 UTC

You can use Ai without outsourcing the computing power to run it. You just don't get the largest, smartest models. You can run them locally on your phone entirely offline, using just a smidge of your phone's battery.

You can use Ai offline, for no more energy than you'd use doing anything else reasonably intensive on your PC. Asking a LLM a question on your own computer is using a lot less resources than you playing fortnite or overwatch for hours and hours.

Once the question is asked and answered the GPU is no longer working hard. A llm can answer a question within just a second or two.

Training a model is different, if everyone used open source local models then the impact would mostly be on the training side.

The more training, the more efficient these things can and do get. See deepseek using less resources for the same product (more or less)

If you can get a model good enough to be on your PC, that can REASON well enough then all you have to do is give it correct new information rather than worrying about hallucinations.